

Common eagle ray

Myliobatis aquila

- ↔ 2–6 ft (0.6–1.8 m)
- 📍 E. Atlantic, Mediterranean, SW. Indian Ocean
- ⊗ Not known

Eagle rays have massively expanded triangular pectoral fins for swimming through open waters—most species of rays, in comparison, are bottom-dwellers. Eagle rays' jaws are armed with teeth that form plates for crushing the shells of mollusks and crustaceans. This species, like others, occasionally performs spectacular leaps from the water—perhaps as a way of escaping predators or clearing parasites from the surface of its body.

Smalltooth sawfish

Pristis pectinata

- ↔ 18–25 ft (5.5–7.6 m)
- 📍 W. Atlantic, Indo-Pacific
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Sawfishes have a sharklike body, but are more closely related to rays. Like its relatives, the smalltooth sawfish—also called the wide sawfish—has an elongated snout that is about one-quarter of its body length. The snout is edged with 23–32 pairs of toothlike projections as well as sensory receptors for detecting prey. The smalltooth sawfish swims close to the bottom of inshore waters, where the “saw” is swept from side to side to disturb and immobilize prey living in the sediment.

Spotted ratfish

Hydrolagus colliei

- ↔ 7–24 in (18–61 cm)
- 📍 E. North Pacific
- ⊗ Locally common

Ratfishes—also called chimaeras—are big-headed cousins of sharks. They share their cartilaginous skeleton, but differ from sharks in having their gill slits covered by a flap of skin and in having rubbery, instead of sandpaperlike, skin. Like other ratfish species, the spotted ratfish has a ratlike tail, wingslike pectoral fins, a dorsal fin spine, a downward-facing mouth equipped with platelike teeth for crushing hard-shelled invertebrates, and a sensory snout for detecting prey buried in sediment.



Other species

- Ribbontail stingray
Taeniura lymma » p304
- Scalloped hammerhead shark
Sphyrna lewini » pp348–49
- Whale shark
Rhincodon typus » pp306–07

Bony fish

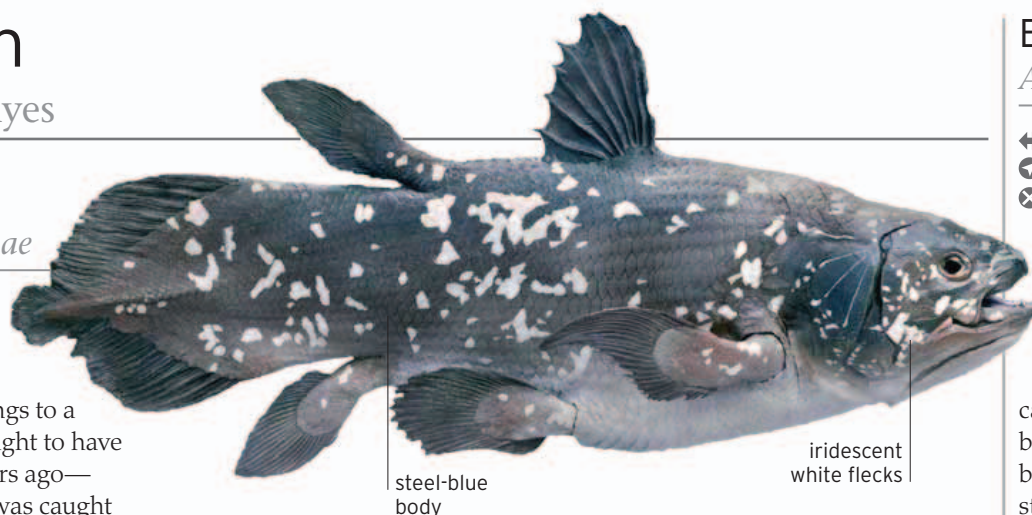
Class Osteichthyes

Coelacanth

Latimeria chalumnae

- ↔ Up to 6 ft (2 m)
- 📍 W. Indian Ocean
- ⊗ Critically endangered

This “living fossil” belongs to a lineage of fish once thought to have died out 400 million years ago—until a living specimen was caught in 1938. The coelacanth is found at depths of 500–2,300 ft (150–700 m) along rocky slopes with submarine caverns swept by strong oceanic



currents. It has fleshy fins and is closely related to lungfish, but the way it evolved in relation to other

vertebrates is not completely understood. Today, it uses its fins as stabilizers in deep waters.

European sturgeon

Acipenser sturio

- ↔ Up to 11 ft (3.5 m)
- 📍 North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Europe
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Sturgeons make up a family of northern circumpolar fish. Although classified with bony fishes, its skeleton is composed of both bone and cartilage. The skin lacks scales, but is covered with an armor of bony plates instead. The European sturgeon breeds in cold, gravel-bottomed river waters, where it produces an astonishing output of up to 6 million eggs at a single spawning.

Arapaima

Arapaima gigas

- ↔ Up to 10 ft (3 m)
- 📍 N. South America
- ⊗ Not known

One of the biggest freshwater fish, the arapaima is a long-bodied predator of Amazon swamplands with particularly hard scales. A lunglike swim bladder and a specialized organ located above the gills that lets it take in air from the water surface help the arapaima to survive in warm, stagnant pools with little oxygen.

European eel

Anguilla anguilla

- ↔ Up to 3 ft (1 m)
- 📍 E. North Atlantic, Mediterranean, Europe
- ⊗ Critically endangered

Eels are snakelike fish that lack pelvic fins and girdles. Most species live permanently in ocean

waters, but the European eel spends its adult life in freshwater rivers. It migrates to saltwaters to breed, spawning in the North Atlantic's Sargasso Sea. Typical of eels, the eggs hatch into transparent larvae. These migrate back to European rivers, developing first into silvery, pigmented juveniles called elvers before maturing into adults.

continuous dorsal, anal, and tailfin

narrow, pointed snout of adults

